

"The" & "A": #5. Main Exceptions

A Quick-Reference Guide

<u>Assorted set-phrases:</u> "the least bit" - He wasn't the least bit tired. "go home" - I want to go home. Please go home.		<u>Titles:</u> She is/was the president. or She is/was president. She is head chef. or She was the head chef.
<u>Names of Specific Businesses:</u> We are going to... the : olive garden, [none] : chili's, denny's, starbucks, john's restaurant, dominos, TGI-Friday's, a : chilies, denny's, starbucks, dominos, any : California pizza kitchen,	- I'm going to Best Western. - I'm going to the Hilton Hotel.	<u>Country Names:</u> the United States the Ukraine the USSR the US the UK the republic of...

Common Exception Patterns:

1. Places Around Town:

- going to **the** store (there is not "just one" or "just one famous," yet this phrase is the only standard)
- go to **the** bank (there is not "just one" or "just one famous," yet this phrase is the only standard)
- **the** doctor (there is not "just one" or "just one famous," yet this phrase is the only standard)
- went to **the** hospital/in **the** hospital ("a hospital" is uncommon) (there is not "just one" or "just one famous," yet this phrase is the only standard) (British English: see below)
- **the** mall (there is not "just one" or "just one famous," yet this phrase is the only standard)

2. In a restaurant:

For whatever reason, restaurants are places where many linguistic exceptions occur.

"a" and "the" become more interchangeable.

"May I please have a fish sandwich?" or "May I please have the fish sandwich?" (both are ok)

3. Special very formal names often have a "the" in the title:

"go to **the** Jack Kennedy Library for the Visually Impaired" (a special building's name)

vs. "go to Jack's Bookshop" (a normal building's name)

"I am flying into **the** Ronald Reagan International Airport." (a special building's name)

vs. "I am flying over Ron's shop." (a normal building's name)

4. Nuance/Meaning Difference:

Give me money. (Asking for money, as in begging from a stranger.)

Give me a dollar. (Asking for money, or pooling money (e.g. when paying as a group).)

Give me some money. (Asking a friend to borrow money.)

Give me **the** money. (A robbery.)

5. Neither:

"University": In the US and UK "University" has no "the" or "a," just by tradition.

"hopsital": In British English (not US English), people say "go to hospital."